

POWERFUL WESTERLIES

Over the cooler oceans of the temperate zones, the prevailing winds blow from west to east. Since winds are always named according to where they blow from, they are known as westerlies. Near the polar regions they blow more strongly, especially in the Southern Ocean around Antarctica.

► SOUTHERN OCEAN

In the far south, where there are no continents to hamper airflow, the strong westerlies are called the Roaring Forties.



POLAR EASTERLIES

Over the icy seas near the North and South poles, air flowing away from the poles toward the warmer temperate zones veers west. This means that the prevailing winds over the cold polar oceans blow from east to west. They drive the floating pack ice west too, especially in the Arctic Ocean and the Antarctic Weddell and Ross seas.

▲ ANTARCTIC BLIZZARD

A cold polar easterly picks up loose snow and hurls it at these tents pitched on the sea ice near the shores of Antarctica.



CALM ZONES

Between the tropical trade wind zones and the westerly wind belts lie calm zones where there is very little wind from any direction. Similar calm regions, called the doldrums, occur near the equator. These windless zones were a serious problem in the days of sailing ships with no engines. Ships could be trapped in doldrums for weeks, and often ran out of food and fresh water.